
IM0802 – Responsible Artificial Intelligence

Assignment 1: Deepfakes in time of conflict or war

Harman Preet Singh¹

852863316

(temporary) resources

- Scientific [1]
- Scientific [2]
- News/blog article [3]
- Book [4]

1 Introduction

A United Nations Security Council (UNSC) meeting is underway to vote on a ceasefire agreement. The conflict in question has been ongoing for years, with both sides accusing each other of war crimes and atrocities with little concrete evidence to support either claim. That is, until a video surfaces online showing militants from one side of the conflict carrying out organised killings of unarmed civilians in a disputed border region. The video quickly goes viral, is shared by news outlets and social media, and sparks outrage worldwide. Protests are organised by human rights organisations in major cities, trending hashtags call for justice, and the video becomes a rallying point for condemnation of the accused nation. Diplomats and politicians condemn the actions, and the UNSC votes to impose sanctions on the accused nation based on the video evidence. The accused nation denies the allegations, claiming the video is fabricated, but the damage is done. Diplomatic relations have been severed and economic sanctions are in place. These economic sanctions eventually lead to the accused nation's economy collapsing and them being forced to withdraw from the conflict.

However, there is more to the story. The killings never happened. The video was a deepfake, generated by the government of the opposing nation to discredit the accused nation. Generative artificial intelligence has made significant advancements, with recently the footage being almost indistinguishable from real footage. Until not very long ago, deepfakes were not very convincing, and were mostly used for entertainment purposes. But in 2026, the advancements of generative artificial intelligence could very well be used to fabricate a video with deepfake technology to influence international diplomacy. This essay will explore the ethical implications of deepfakes in time of conflict or war.

2 Issue

Briefly explain what deepfake technology is, how generative AI enables it, and how it has evolved from crude face-swaps to near-indistinguishable video. Draw on [2] and/or [1] for the technical grounding

Discuss concrete documented cases of AI-generated disinformation being deployed in active conflicts, using the DFRLab report on Ukraine [3] as the primary source. Establish that this is not purely hypothetical.

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Identify the key stakeholder groups — civilian populations, opposing governments, international bodies (e.g. the UN), journalists, and the general public — and explain how deepfakes produce consequences for each. [2] and [1] are both relevant here.

Argue that wartime propaganda and deception are not new, but that AI fundamentally changes the scale, accessibility, and believability of disinformation. Reference [4] for the cultural/epistemic dimension of deepfakes eroding trust in visual evidence

Discuss how pre-existing conditions — political polarisation, weakened media literacy, fractured international trust — amplify the impact of deepfakes. The point is that AI is the accelerant, not the sole cause

3 Solution

4 Conclusions

References

- [1] Berkant Akkuş. Deepfakes and the geneva conventions: Does deceptive ai-generated misinformation directed at an enemy during armed conflict violate international humanitarian law? a critical discussion. *Laws*, 14(6), 2025. ISSN 2075-471X. doi: 10.3390/laws14060083. URL <https://www.mdpi.com/2075-471X/14/6/83>.
- [2] Pascal Muam Mah. The role of deepfake, deception, and disinformation in conflict zones based on dl for nlp: A critical ai-era perspective. *Comunicar*, 34(84):228–246, 2026. doi: 10.5281/zenodo.18115680. URL <https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.18115680>.
- [3] Roman Osadchuk. Ai tools usage for disinformation in the war in ukraine, Jul 9 2024. URL <https://dfrlab.org/2024/07/09/ai-tools-usage-for-disinformation-in-the-war-in-ukraine/>. Digital Forensic Research Lab (DFRLab) report.
- [4] Sarah Kenderdine and Lily Hibberd. *Deep Fakes: A Critical Lexicon for Digital Museology*. Routledge, 10 2025. ISBN 9781003334453. doi: 10.4324/9781003334453.

¹<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=X17yrEV5sl4>